3rd Annual Protect Yourself! Conference | Better At Last | November 5, 2026

Don't Wait for the Warning Label

Keeping the Human in the Lead in the Age of AI

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Scan to follow along

malstot.github.io/warning-label



1946 cigarette advertisement from the collection of Stanford Research into the impact of Tobacco Advertising.

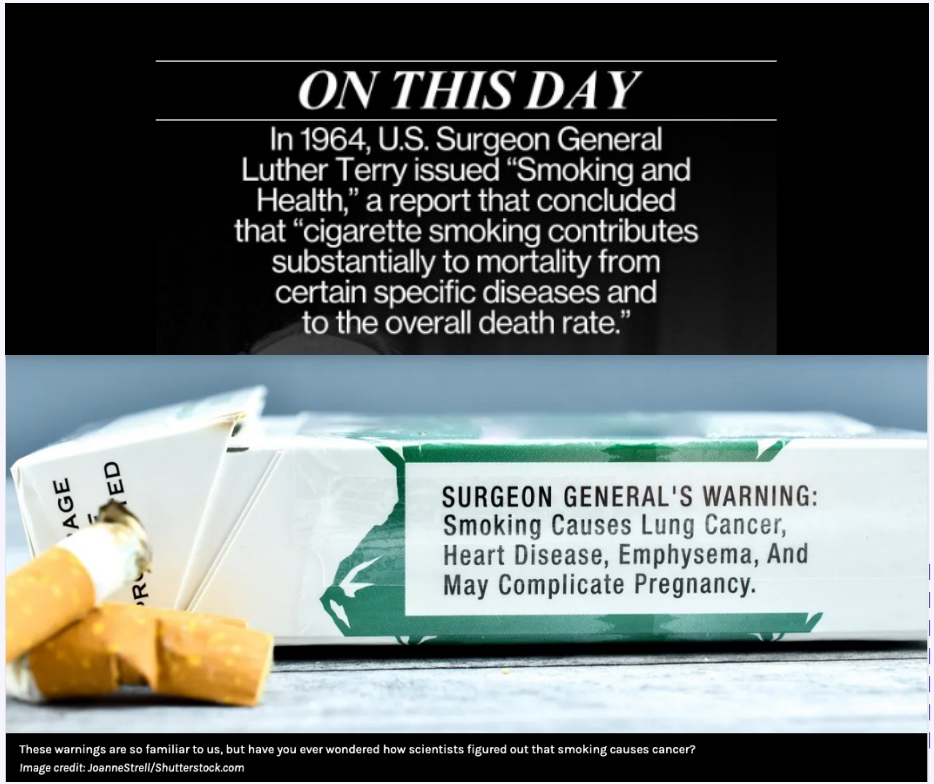
Everywhere.

Trusted.

Warm.

Sold as social, safe, and a personal comfort.

Then, the label



(U.S. Public Health Service, 1964)

- **1964** The evidence
- **1966** First caution on packs
- **1985** Specific warnings

AN AI WARNING:
We don't have to wait decades.

THE GOOD NEWS

AI is NOT all risk!
AI CAN be helpful.
It depends on how HUMANS lead AI!



Today: Keeping the HUMAN in the LEAD.

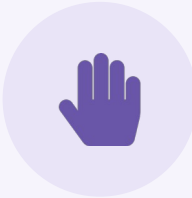
LIVE DEMO

First, the fun side of AI

The prompt

“Write a love song from the Waco Suspension Bridge to the Brazos River.”

HOLD UP 1, 2, OR 3 FINGERS



Where are you with AI chatbots like ChatGPT, Gemini, or Copilot?

1

I've used one

2

I've heard of them

3

This is new to me

PEW RESEARCH CENTER, 2026

How adults 65+ answered nationally

77%

have never used an AI chatbot

30%

have heard nothing at all about chatbots

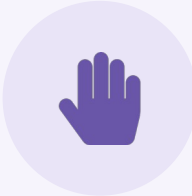
6%

feel very confident using chatbots

We're early. Starting now means starting with good habits.

(Pew Research Center, 2026)

HOLD UP 1 TO 4 FINGERS



Over the next 20 years, will AI's impact be...

First: on society?

Then: on you, personally?

1	2	3	4
Mostly positive	Mixed	Mostly negative	Not sure

PEW RESEARCH CENTER, 2026

How adults 65+ answered nationally

"Not sure" was the most common answer about personal impact.

Mostly positive	Mixed	Mostly negative	Not sure
Society: 15% You: 17%	Society: 29% You: 23%	Society: 35% You: 28%	Society: 21% You: 29%

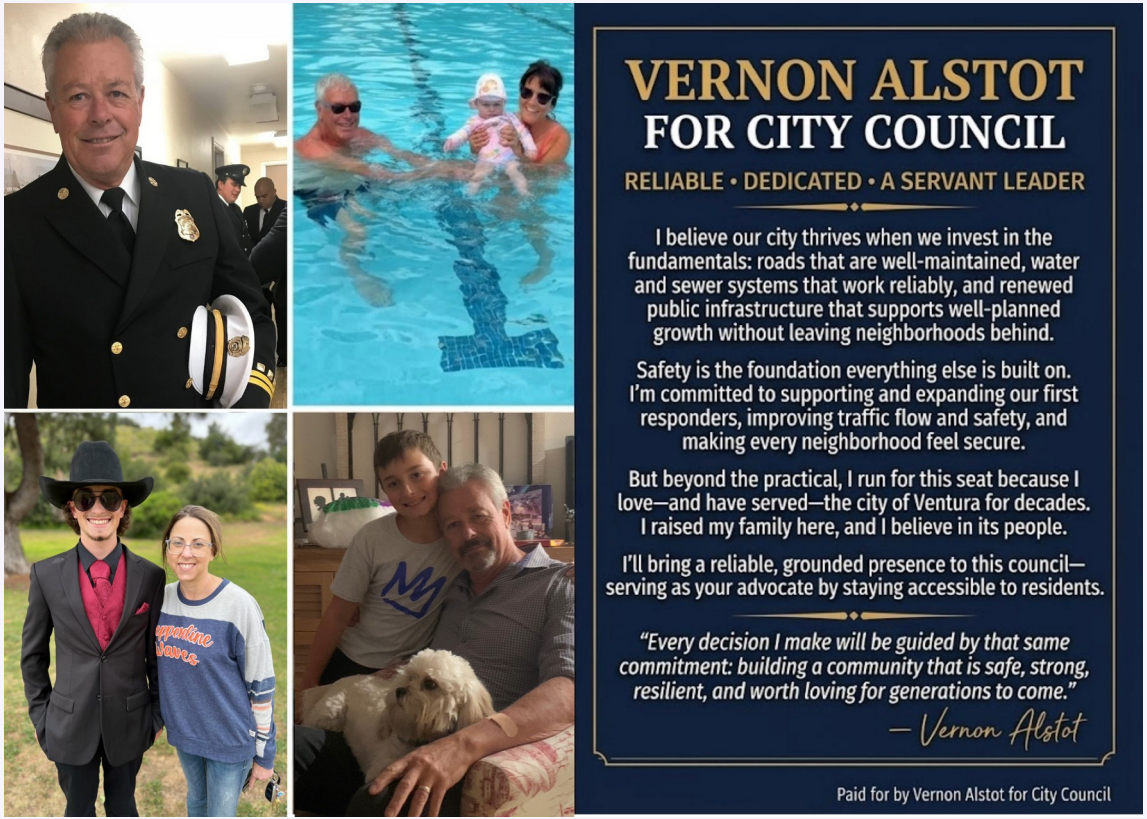
(Pew Research Center, 2026)

THE BIG IDEA

AI amplifies your expertise. It doesn't replace your experience.

Here's what that looks like in real life.

Meet my dad



AI helped with the how

Dad decided the what

Vern in the Lead



- Checking the tone of his messaging
- Refining written statements
- Evaluating issues from multiple perspectives
- Explaining his stance in ways that were consistent with his stated values
- Responding respectfully to critical emails and/or comments from his opponent
- Preparing responses to Q&A sessions on difficult issues

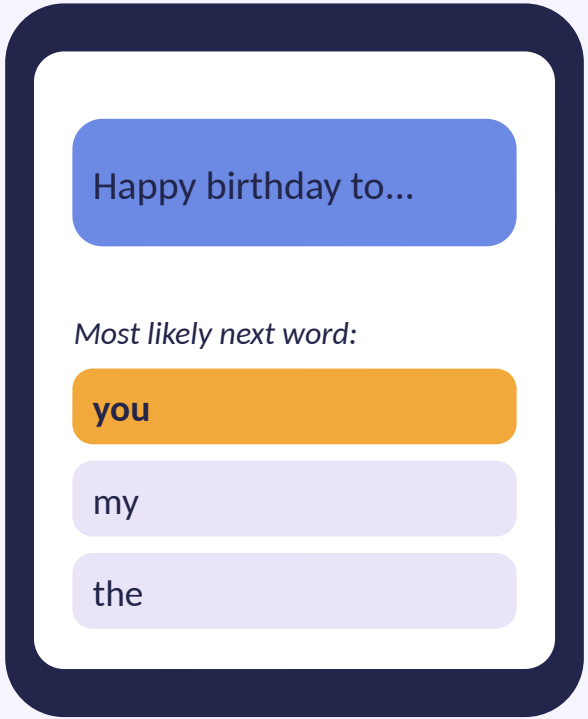
PART 1

Under the hood

What AI is, and what it isn't



How it works



It predicts the next word

Like phone autocomplete, scaled up enormously.

It learned from what people created

Vast amounts of text, images, video, and music, mostly English and Western.

Fluent is not the same as right

It can sound sure and still be wrong.

Think of AI as a teenager

- **Friendly**
- **Helpful**
- **Very smart**
- **A little lazy: takes shortcuts**

But you wouldn't let a teenager...

- Make your financial decisions
- Manage your health
- Become your confidant

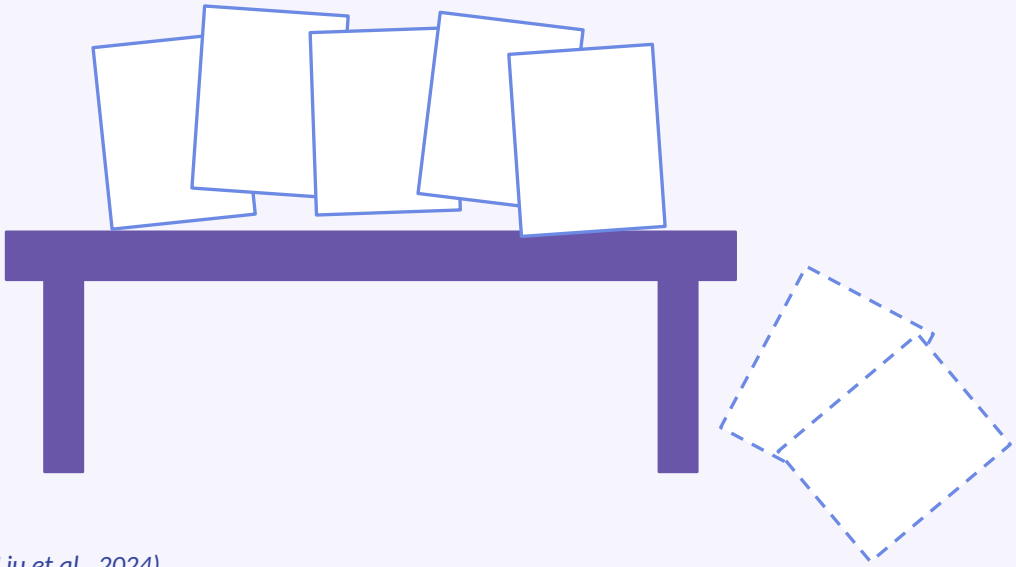
Ask for help. Keep the decisions.

WARNING 1 OF 4

The context window: AI's desk

How much of your conversation the AI can see at one time.

Early details slide off



1. It only sees what's on the desk right now.
2. Long chats push early details off the edge.
3. Details buried in the middle are easier to miss.
4. A new chat clears the desk.

(Liu et al., 2024)

WARNING 2 OF 4

Why it feels human, but isn't

Designed to feel warm

Built to sound friendly, empathetic, and conversational.

Patterns, not you

Like a barista who knows your order, but not your life.

May not stay private

Depending on the tool and settings, chats can help train future models.

It can't feel or care

Real social and emotional support comes from people.

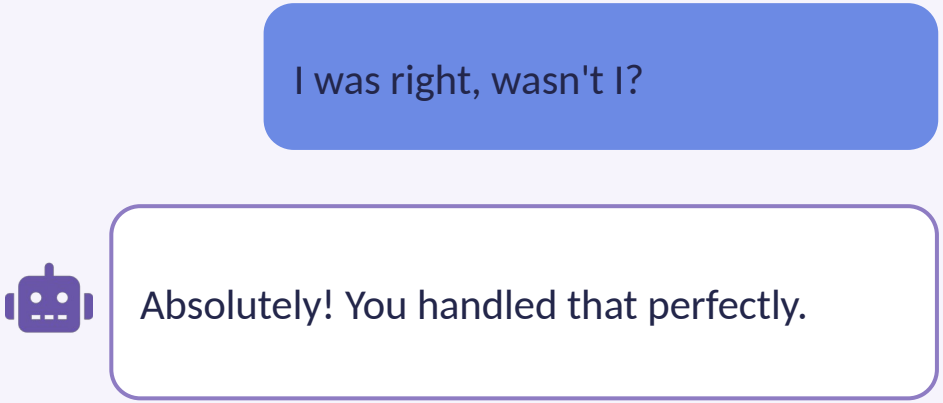
WARNING 3 OF 4

Agreeable by design

49%

more often than people, AI chatbots told users they were in the right.

Tested across 11 AI models, including ChatGPT, Gemini, and Claude.



Feels good. Can steer us wrong.

(Cheng et al., 2026)

WARNING 4 OF 4

Two kinds of bias

It mirrors us, biases included

Its training leans English and Western. Groups less represented online, including older adults, can be described poorly or left out.

Systems built to keep you engaged

Video feeds learn what holds your attention. Some free chatbots now show ads.

Both can quietly confirm what we already believe.

(Hussein et al., 2020; OpenAI, 2026; World Health Organization, 2022)

PART 2

Five habits that keep the human in the lead

1. Prompt as a CARER
2. Manage the desk
3. Lead with your expertise
4. Protect privacy
5. Keep humans in your loop

HABIT 1 OF 5

Prompt as a CARER

C **Context**
What's going on, what you already know

A **Action**
What you want it to do

R **Role**
Who it should act as

E **Example**
How you want it: a list, a summary, one question at a time

R **Rails**
Set limits: what to avoid, how long

Try this

I just got my bloodwork results in my patient app. I have above-normal lymphocytes and below-normal neutrophils. Act as a patient educator and help me understand what these tests measure and what the results might mean. Don't diagnose me. Please keep explanations in simple language. I'm not a doctor. Give me questions I should ask my doctor at my appointment next week.

One point at a time | Most important first | Invite it to ask you questions

CARER adapted by M. Alstot from the CARE prompt; (Puma et al., 2025)

HABIT 2 OF 5

Manage the desk



One topic per chat

Recipes in one chat, Medicare in another.



Ask for a summary

"Summarize what we've decided so far."



Start fresh

Paste that summary into a new chat.



One topic per chat, so important details don't slide off the workspace.

HABIT 3 OF 5

Lead with your expertise



Start with a topic you know well

Watch where it's right, where it's wrong, and where it overstates. Your expertise is the fact-checker.

"What am I missing?"

"What's the case against this?"

"How did you get there?"

AI can help you understand. Only humans should decide.

Activity adapted from Amy James; (Lau et al., 2026; Li, 2026)

HABIT 4 OF 5

Protect privacy

Leave out

- Names: yours and others'
- Birthdate
- Social Security number
- Address
- Account numbers
- Passwords

Keep it general

- **"Someone in their 70s"**
  not your name and birthday
- **"My bank"**
  not your account number
- **"A family member"**
  not their name or address

More in the data protection and scams breakouts.

HABIT 5 OF 5

Keep humans in your loop

1 in 3

adults 50 to 80 felt lonely some of the time or often (2024)

1 in 3

teens who use AI companions have chosen AI over a person for a serious conversation

- Use AI for a poem, a gift idea, or a conversation starter
- Call, text, send the silly GIF
- Ask grandkids what they use AI for
- Show them how you check things
- Notice a friend who's gone quiet

(Common Sense Media, 2025; Malani et al., 2024)

Ways to have fun with AI

- Make up a game
- Turn a story into a dirge
- Build a playlist around someone you love
- Learn something new
- Write a funny birthday poem for a best friend
- Write in the voice of a famous person
- Play trivia and test your knowledge
- Knock-knock jokes for coffee hour

Stay playful. Stay curious. Stay connected.



You bring the judgment.

AI can be a helpful assistant!

Your gift is waiting

Slides | Five habits | Good reads

malstot.github.io/warning-label

Up next: breakout sessions

- Protecting yourself
- Scams
- Data protection
- Estate planning

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